

you) can report your income to the IRS come tax time. A W-9 can be downloaded from the official IRS website.

If you have people working for you, you could ask them to fill one out. If you're working as a freelancer or consultant, the company you're working for will give you a standard blank 1099 before you start so you can put in your name and Social Security number. (Because the form has this sensitive information, think twice about emailing it or to whom you send it.)

WHAT IS A 1099?

Ah, my old friend the 1099! This one is for freelancers and is sent to you by the company paying you. It's one of the papers you have to bring to the accountant or H&R Block in your accordion folder of random papers and receipts. (Just me?)

If you have a day job, then this is for any income you make outside it. My entire income is freelance. This makes taxes a nightmare because instead of calculating deductions from one place, Accountant Dan calculates them from every publication I wrote for once, every acting gig or TV job, every branded deal on the YouTube channel, and every small task I did and forgot about until the 1099s come in the mail. A big help would have been to keep track of all the jobs I did in that year, something I have never done.

WHAT I SHOULD HAVE DONE

According to my accountant, this is what I should have done.

ALWAYS KEEP A CALENDAR

Since I was in the third grade, I've kept a paper planner where I write down my whole schedule at the beginning of every week. I'm also neurotic, so once a task is completed, I scratch it out in pen. I was 28 when my manager, Matt, insisted I get a Google calendar. Before that, if I didn't have my trusty paper planner with me, I had no idea what I was doing that day or what I had done as recently as the day before.